

SHANMUGA RATNAM SIVAKUMAR

Level Designer · Action & Combat · Unreal Engine 5

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SUMMARY

Level Designer with **3+ years of full-time Unreal Engine 5 experience**, specializing in fast-paced action games and competitive arena design. Led level design on **Mechanical Fury**, a movement shooter published on Steam (6-person team) — **12 combat arenas and 20+ enemy encounters** built from blackout to first playable with three-phase encounter progression and balanced difficulty curves. **15+ levels shipped** across action, horror, and multiplayer. Strong on combat encounter design, verticality-focused layouts, action pacing, navmesh-driven enemy AI, and Blueprint scripting — plus procedural tools that cut blackout time. **Based in Chennai and available to join on-site immediately.**

EXPERIENCE

Certified Listeners Society (CLS), Canada — Gamification & Systems Designer, Contract **April 2026 – Present**

Gamified web + mobile platform · Remote

- Design the gamification and progression systems end-to-end — streaks, leaderboards, milestone unlocks, and reward loops tuned to lift user return-rate and engagement.
- Own the core-loop and reward-pacing spec; prototype, document, and iterate from real user feedback across design, engineering, and product.

Avian Hearts — Level Designer / Technical Designer (Full-Time) **November 2023 – November 2025**

Project: Mechanical Fury · Fast-paced movement shooter · Published on Steam (Early Access) · Team of 6 · Unreal Engine 5, Blueprints, Niagara, Materials, Jira, SourceTree

- Designed **12 distinct combat arenas and 20+ unique enemy encounters** across two episodes (E1M1–E2M3), taken from blackout to first playable — verticality-focused layouts, clean sightlines, cover, and traversal that kept pressure high in a movement-shooter loop.
- Built **three-phase encounter progression** with balanced difficulty curves; designed and tuned the full enemy roster (fodder, heavies, bosses, drones) — combat behaviour, navmesh AI, custom drone logic, and spawn rules for readable, high-intensity action.
- Owned intensity pacing across every level — shaping when the player feels in control, when tension spikes, and when survival feels razor-thin.
- Built **procedural level-design tools** with the artist that cut blackout time ~40% and sped up iteration; kept levels clean with naming conventions, layers, and world-partition practices.
- Scripted gameplay in Blueprints: traps, doors, triggers, objectives, extraction points, and smooth level transitions; rapid-prototyped mechanics before final implementation.
- Ran playtests, captured feedback, logged issues in Jira, and iterated fast to improve readability, pacing, and combat feel.

Highavenue Creative Labs (Target Force) — Game Designer, Contract **December 2025 – March 2026**

Mobile PvPvE battle royale · 30-player · Unreal Engine 5, Blueprints · Remote

- Designed NPC combat systems (Giant Spiders, Alert Wolves) — AI behaviour, spawn mechanics, and difficulty scaling tuned for readable, aggressive encounters across a 30-player arena.
- Authored combat and encounter documentation covering artifact mechanics, difficulty scaling, and mobile performance budgets — a single source of truth across engineering, art, and QA.

IMU Studios — Underground Level Designer, Freelance

March 2023 – July 2023

Underground combat module · Unreal Engine, Blueprints · Remote

- Designed and whiteboxed underground combat spaces — tunnels, caverns, vertical shafts, and enclosed arenas — with a focus on player flow, sightlines, and choke-point control.
- Built modular layouts and implemented level logic in Blueprints (triggers, player gating, encounter setup); iterated on layouts from playtest feedback.

FEATURED PROJECTS

Fresh Color Horror — Single-Player Horror Level

June 2022 – January 2023

Unreal Engine 4, Blueprints, Niagara, Materials, SourceTree

- Designed and built a complete level from greybox to polished experience — pacing curves for tension and release, scripted scare sequences (Blueprint triggers / timelines), and custom interaction systems for environmental storytelling.

Kickback — 2D Multiplayer Action

2023 – Present

Unity, C#, Photon, Jira

- Designed 2D action levels for flow, balance, and intense combat moments; integrated multiplayer-specific features for dynamic, competitive player interactions.

Ragball — Party Arena Action

March 2022 – May 2022

Unity, Shader Graph, C#, ProBuilder, Git · British Columbia Game Jam 2022 — 1st Place

- Created arena designs and refined gameplay flow through iterative testing; built a custom "Squash and Stretch with Flapping Feet" character controller for responsive movement feel.

EDUCATION

Vancouver Film School, Canada — Diploma in Game Design

December 2021 – January 2023

Sri Venkateswara College of Engineering (SVCE), Chennai — B.Tech, Information Technology

May 2016 – December 2020

TECHNICAL SKILLS

- **Engines:** Unreal Engine 5, Unity
- **Scripting:** Blueprints, C#, Visual Scripting, Shader Graph, HLSL
- **Level Design:** blockout / whitebox, combat encounter design, action pacing, sightlines & cover, traversal, choke points, difficulty tuning, world partition, GDD writing
- **AI & Systems:** NavMesh, NPC / enemy behaviour, spawn & difficulty scaling, trap & trigger logic
- **Tools:** Jira, Git, SourceTree, Blender, Photoshop, ProBuilder, TrenchBroom, Niagara, Material Editor
- **Workflow:** playtesting & iteration, bug tracking, on-site & remote team collaboration across art, engineering, and QA

RECOGNITION

- Published **Mechanical Fury** (movement shooter) on Steam — team of 6; **15+ levels designed** across action, horror, and multiplayer.
- **British Columbia Game Jam 2022 — 1st Place** for innovative gameplay design (Ragball).
- **Best Narrative Designer (2022) · Best Final Project Award**, Vancouver Film School.